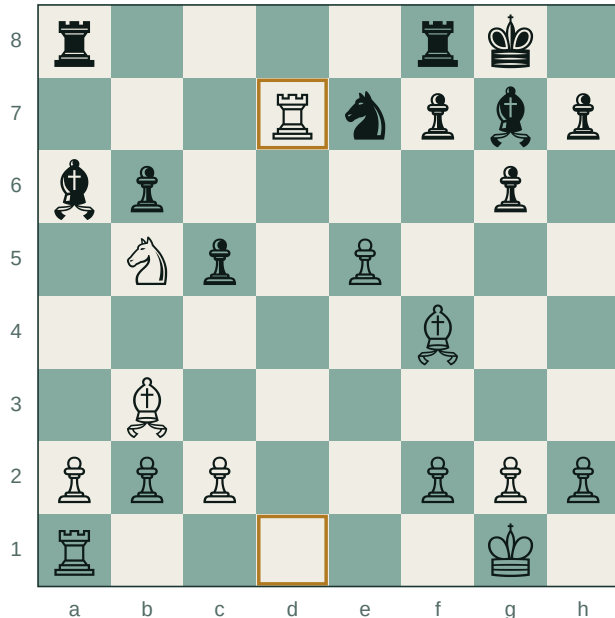


# Trapping a piece: Black, move 17

Trapping a piece

Black to move



Previous move: 17.Rxd7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**17...Bxb5 18. Rxe7 c4 19. Bxc4 Bxc4**

**17...Bxb5** The bishop captures the knight on b5. Recorded reply: **18.Rxe7**.

**18...c4** The pawn moves from c5 to c4. Recorded reply: **19.Bxc4**.

**19...Bxc4** The bishop captures the bishop on c4.

At the end, nominal material is White 20 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

**CHECKPOINT**

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from -2 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: rook on d7 and knight on b5. Check for tactical protection.